targeting key trade partners like China, Canada, and the EU, Trump reinforced the perception of widespread noncompliance, even in cases where no violations existed.

To evaluate Trump's rhetoric, presidential documents archived in the American Presidency Project were used, including speeches, press conferences, and official remarks by Bush, Obama, and Trump. The focus of the analysis was on instances where the word "trade" appeared, identifying trends in word frequency, usage patterns, and sentiment. This analysis revealed a stark contrast between Trump and his immediate predecessors. By extracting the top 100 words associated with "trade" in the speeches of all three presidents, 30 words unique to Trump were identified. These words fall into two distinct categories: First, those related to unfairness and cheating like "deficit," "terrible," "unfair," "bad," and "worst" highlight perceived injustices in trade agreements. Second, those related to demands for change like "renegotiate," "reciprocal," "reform," and "stop" emphasize Trump's calls to overhaul existing trade arrangements.

This analysis raises an important question: Were trade violations increasing, as Trump claimed? To test whether Trump's rhetoric reflected actual increases in trade violations, data from the Global Trade Alert database on trade infractions from 2009 to 2018 were analyzed. Surprisingly, trade violations under Trump were fewer than during Obama's presidency (figure 3.2), suggesting that Trump's rhetoric was largely decoupled from reality.